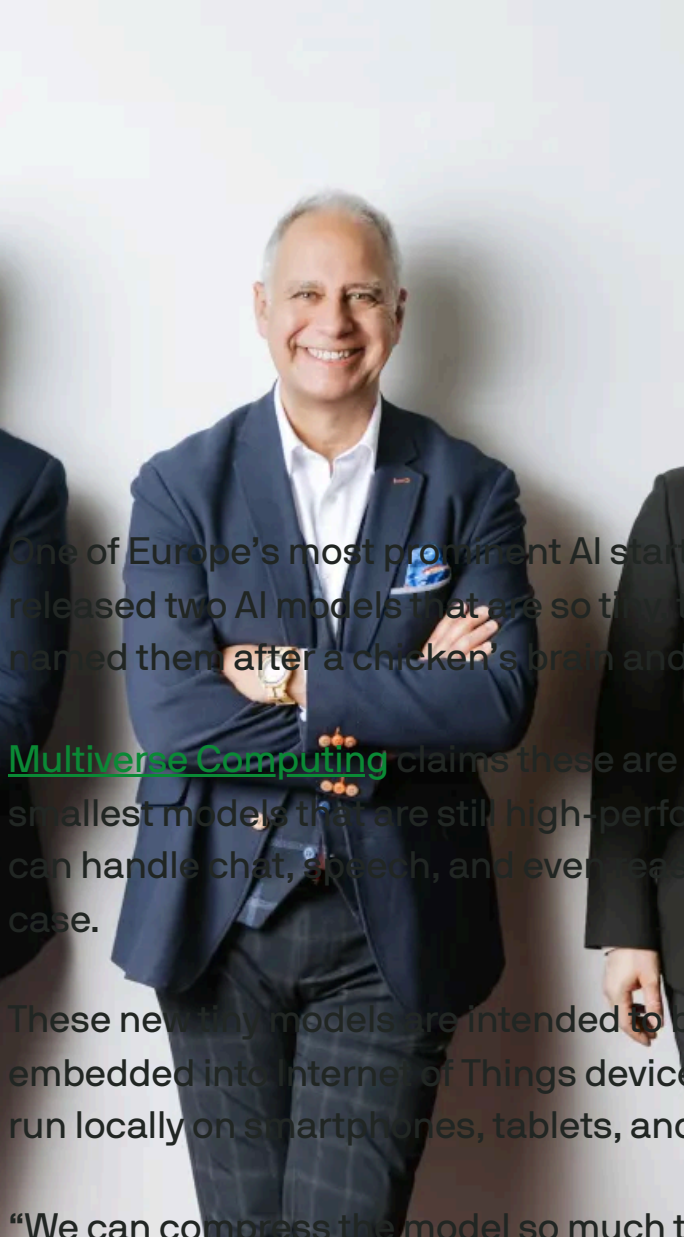


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AI



**Buzzy AI startup
Multiverse creates two of
the smallest high-
performing models ever**



One of Europe's most prominent AI startups has released two AI models that are so tiny they have named them after a chicken's brain and a fly's brain.

Multiverse Computing claims these are the world's smallest models that are still high-performing and can handle chat, speech, and even reasoning in one case.

These new tiny models are intended to be embedded into Internet of Things devices, as well as run locally on smartphones, tablets, and PCs.

“We can compress the model so much that they can fit on devices,” founder Román Orús told TechCrunch. “You can run them on premises, directly on your iPhone, or on your Apple Watch.”

As we previously reported, Multiverse Computing is a buzzy European AI startup headquartered in Donostia, Spain, with about 100 employees in offices worldwide. It was co-founded by a top European professor of quantum computers and physics, Román Orús; quantum computing expert Samuel Mugel; and Enrique Lizaso Olmos, the former deputy CEO of Unnim Banc.

It just raised **€189 million (about \$215 million)** in June on the strength of a model compression technology it calls “CompactifAI.” (Since it was founded in 2019, it has raised about \$250 million, Orús said.)

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CompactifAI is a quantum-inspired compression algorithm that reduces the size of existing AI models without sacrificing those models' performance, Orús said.



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“We have a compression technology that is not the typical compression technology that the people from computer science or machine learning will do, because we come from quantum physics,” he described. “It’s a more subtle and more refined compression algorithm.”

The company has already released a long list of compressed versions of open source models, especially popular small models like [Llama 4 Scout](#) or [Mistral Small 3.1](#). And it just launched compressed versions of [OpenAI’s two new open models](#). It has also compressed some very large models — it offers a DeepSeek R1 Slim, for instance.

But since it’s in the business of making models smaller, it has focused extra attention on making the smallest yet most powerful models possible.

Its two new models are so small that they can bring chat AI capabilities to just about any IoT device and work without an internet connection, the company says. It humorously calls this family the Model Zoo because it's naming the products based on animal brain sizes.

A model it calls SuperFly is a compressed version of Hugging Face's open source model SmolLM2-135. The original has 135 million parameters and was developed for on-device uses. SuperFly is 94 million parameters, which Orús likens to the size of a fly's brain. "This is like having a fly, but a little bit more clever," he said.

SuperFly is designed to be trained on very restricted data, like a device's operations. Multiverse envisions it embedded into home appliances, allowing users to operate them with voice commands like "start quick wash" for a washing machine. Or users can ask troubleshooting questions. With a little processing power (like an Arduino), the model can handle a voice interface, as the company showed in a live demo to TechCrunch.

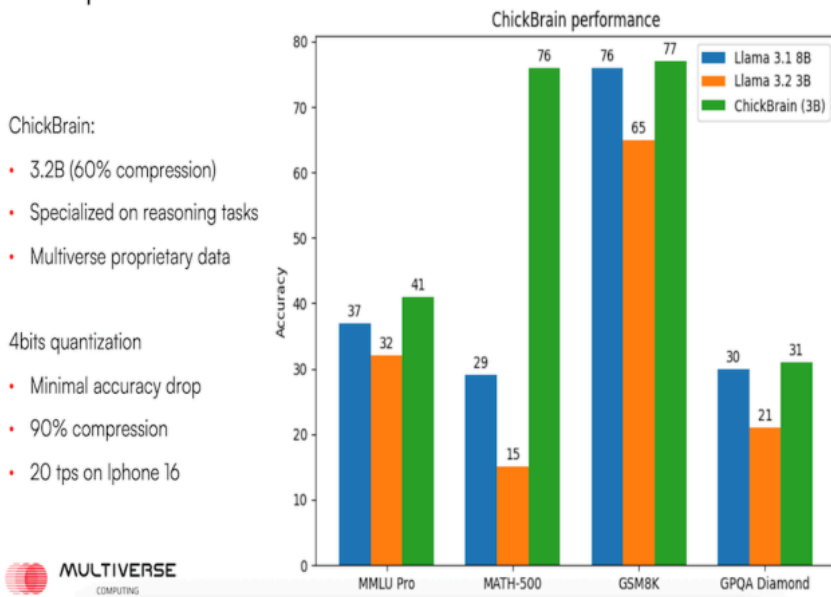
The other model is named ChickBrain, and is larger at 3.2 billion parameters, but is also far more capable and has reasoning capabilities. It's a compressed version of Meta's Llama 3.1 8B model, Multiverse says. Yet it's small enough to run on a MacBook, no internet connection required.

More importantly, Orús said that ChickBrain actually slightly outperforms the original in several standard benchmarks, including the language-skill benchmark MMLU-Pro, math skills benchmarks Math 500 and GSM8K, and the general knowledge benchmark GPQA Diamond.

Here are the results of Multiverse's internal tests of ChickBrain on the benchmarks. The company didn't offer benchmark results for SuperFly but Multiverse

also isn't targeting SuperFly at use cases that require reasoning.

CompactifAI on Llama 3.1 8B Instruct



MULTIVERSE COMPUTING'S CHICKBRAIN BENCHMARKS

IMAGE CREDITS: MULTIVERSE COMPUTING

It's important to note that Multiverse isn't claiming that its Model Zoo will beat the largest state-of-the-art models on such benchmarks. Zoo performances might not even land on the leaderboards. The point is that its tech can shrink model size without a performance hit, the company says.

Orús says the company is already in talks with all the leading device and appliance makers. "We are talking with Apple. We are talking with Samsung, also with Sony and with HP, obviously. HP came as an investor in the last round," he said. The round was led by well-known European VC firm Bullhound Capital, with participation from a lot of others, including HP Tech Ventures and Toshiba.

The startup also offers compression tech for other forms of machine learning, like image recognition, and in six years has obtained clients like BASF, Ally, Moody's, Bosch, and [others](#).

In addition to selling its models directly to major device manufacturers, Multiverse offers its [compressed models](#) via an API hosted on AWS that

any developer can use, often at lower token fees than competitors.

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IMAGE CREDITS: EIGHT SLEEP / EIGHT SLEEP

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Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Roughly [one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep](#), driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#),

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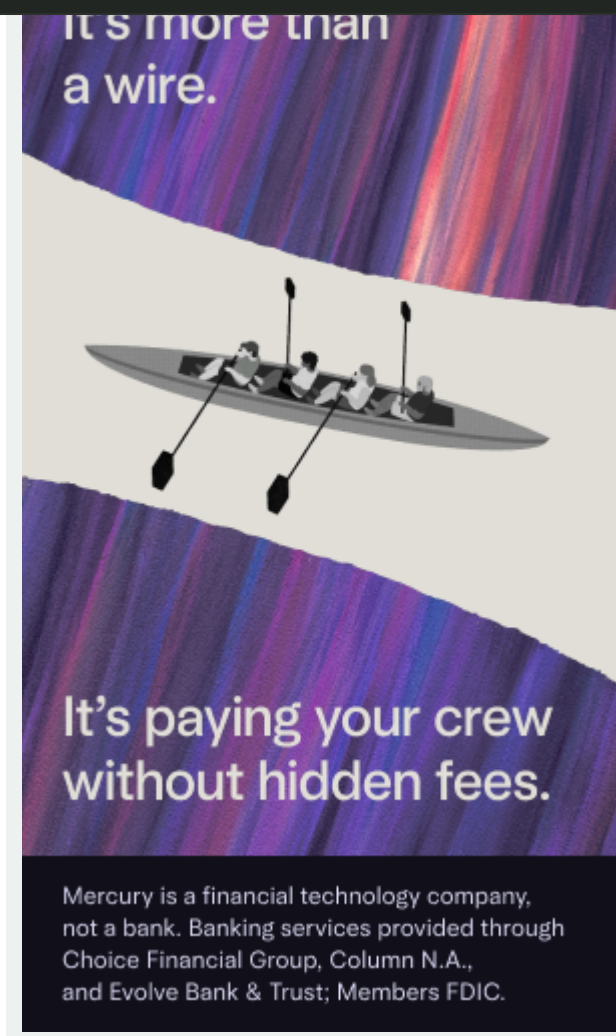
[valuation](#). Eight Sleep said its valuation has doubled since its last round, but didn't disclose specifics.

"If we successfully execute our AI roadmap, launch internationally, and develop condition-specific interventions, achieving unicorn status will naturally follow," Alexandra Zatarain, co-founder and CMO of Eight Sleep, told TechCrunch.

Eight offers smart mattresses that integrate software and AI to track and enhance sleep quality. Its flagship product, Pod, offers features like measuring sleep stages, heart rate, breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it automatically adjusts temperature, elevation, and firmness. It can also detect snoring and automatically elevate the base in response, according to the company.

The company has generated more than \$500 million in Pod sales, expanded its revenue tenfold since launching the product in 2019, and collected insights from over one billion hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.



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The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight’s core differentiator, Autopilot, “builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed,” Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod’s health-monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

“We’re not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you

can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care,” Zatarain said.

Eight’s recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod’s real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world’s largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale’s regulations, including for data storage.

“Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don’t use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights,” Zatarain said.

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

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“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has

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Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

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Julie Bort - 5 hours ago

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Isabelle Johannessen
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raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company's "extremely aggressive product roadmap."



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"The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product," Monaco said. "I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it."

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that

happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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